MA ENGLISH • SEMESTER 1

# Block 3 — Unit 3: Robinson Crusoe and Pamela

MILTON TO THE PRE-ROMANTICS • M21EG03DC

Expanded exam notes | Simple teaching + developed argument

Based on the supplied SGOU self-learning material. Use the assigned primary texts for exact quotations and full scene or passage analysis.

## The chapter in one sentence

Defoe and Richardson give detailed accounts of experience while making readers evaluate the relationship between a narrator’s self-description and structures of power.

## Start with a picture

A person writes down what happened and explains why it was reasonable. The detail may be convincing, but a reader can still ask whose interests shape the explanation and whose experience remains outside it.

## 1. Defoe: Robinson Crusoe

Crusoe’s travels, shipwreck, and survival on an island organise a narrative of labour, calculation, invention, and interpretation. He records resources, constructs shelter, and reads his experience through providence.

**Providence** concerns a divine ordering of events. Crusoe’s sense of its meaning is part of the narrative voice, not a neutral account supplied from outside the story.

## 2. Detail and realism

Lists, practical processes, dates, and repeated work create an effect of lived experience. The first-person account invites trust while also arranging the self as resourceful and entitled to control.

Realistic detail does not establish that an event happened or that the narrator’s moral judgement is beyond question.

## 3. Colonial relationships

Crusoe’s naming, possession, and authority become especially visible in his relationship with Friday. A critical reading asks what Friday says and what the narrative does not allow him to explain independently.

Labour and enterprise cannot be separated entirely from slavery, empire, and claims to ownership. Avoid presenting the island as a place without a political history simply because one narrator describes his mastery of it.

## 4. Richardson: Pamela

Pamela Andrews writes letters and accounts of her experience as a servant exposed to the power of Mr B. Threats, pressure, attempted coercion, and resistance give the narrative its central ethical difficulty.

**Epistolary** means organised through letters. Writing can preserve a record, address trusted readers, and become a means of shaping one's own position. Readers encounter both immediate feeling and an account prepared for someone.

## 5. Class, gender, and the ending

The eventual marriage must be read alongside earlier inequalities rather than used to erase them. The narrative invites arguments about virtue, social advancement, sincerity, performance, and the authority of a woman's account.

A critical discussion of the sexual gaze examines who looks, who describes, and whose body becomes subject to power. It should not blame Pamela for another person's coercion or treat every resistance as secretly manipulative.

## 6. Comparing narrative authority

Crusoe's practical account and Pamela's letters make different claims to credibility. Both link inward explanation with social position. The rise of the novel is partly a history of these new ways of presenting experience, not the invention of storytelling from nothing.

## Quick check

1. Does first-person detail guarantee neutrality? **No.**
2. Does Pamela's marriage erase earlier coercion? **No.**
3. Is Crusoe the unquestionable first fiction ever written in English? **No.**

## Build an exam answer

1. Distinguish retrospective account and letters.
2. Explain realism and credibility in Defoe.
3. Examine possession and Friday's representation.
4. Analyse Pamela's writing under unequal power.
5. Evaluate the limits of narrative and marital closure.

## Common mistake to avoid

Do not call Crusoe an uncontested first novel or treat a coercive relationship as ethically settled merely because it ends in marriage.

## Developed exam discussion

### Practice question

How do the novels make first-person experience persuasive and open to criticism?

### Explain the argument in fuller paragraphs

Robinson Crusoe and Pamela develop different forms of experiential authority. Crusoe’s practical detail and retrospective interpretation make his life appear both credible and meaningful. Pamela’s letters place readers close to uncertainty and vulnerability while giving writing a role inside the struggle. In each case, the narrative form is part of the ethical problem rather than a transparent container for it.

Crusoe’s descriptions of work can encourage admiration for perseverance. A colonial reading also asks how that competence becomes a justification for possession and rule. Friday’s dependence on the narrator’s naming and account exposes a limit to the apparent universality of the self-made individual.

Pamela’s writing brings a servant’s experience of pressure into sustained focus. Yet the letter form raises questions about audience, self-presentation, and the act of preserving evidence. The marriage ending remains inseparable from the class and gender hierarchy through which the relationship developed.

A good comparison should therefore explain both the power and the limits of credibility. Detailed narration makes lives compelling; critical reading asks what the detail selects, whose explanation it privileges, and what an ending can or cannot resolve.

### Use the discussion well

Answer the exact question, not every possible topic. Make one clear point per paragraph, support it with a textual detail or a relevant classroom example, and explain its significance. Check exact quotations against the assigned text. The discussion is paraphrase and guidance, not a quotation or a guaranteed exam answer.

## Textbook assignment checklist

The following numbered prompts are retained from the unit for revision. Obvious source errors are discussed in the coverage review; a prompt’s assumptions should not be accepted automatically. These are not predictions or complete written assignments.

1. Discuss the major themes of the novel, Robinson Crusoe.
2. Is Robinson Crusoe a “picaresque” novel?
3. Can Robinson Crusoe be described as the first novel in English given the author’s insistent critique of fiction as a genre? What are the characteristics of the novel that can be found in this seminal text?
4. How does Friday act as a foil to the character of Crusoe? Assess the relationship between the two and bring out the multiple tensions inherent in such a bond.
5. Comment on the plot and structure of Robinson Crusoe. How far is it true to describe it as an episodic tale of adventure?

6. Discuss the Sexual Gaze in Pamela.
7. Is Pamela ultimately a sympathetic character?
8. Give the character sketch of Pamela Andrews.
9. Discuss the complex relationship between Pamela and her employer.